1. *The Conscious Mind* by Chalmers (1996)

1.1. Introduction

1.1.1. Taking Counsciouness Seriously

About consciousness as an "illusion": p. xii

> I have little idea what this could even mean. It seems to me that we are surer of the existence of conscious experience than we are of anything else in the world.

Doesn't an illusion require that there are things that are real, and things that just appear to be real, i.e., those illusions.

Chalmers starts with three constraints

a. Take consciousness seriously

b. Take science seriously

c. Accept consciousness as natural phenomenon

Chalmers considers two problems or perhaps kinds of problems: The easy problems of consciousness that build upon the assumption that it can be understood by analysing cognition and behaviours. The hard problem is that those problems are insufficient for understanding the consciousness. These two sets of problems are on the opposite ends of a "Great Divide". If you hold that the answer to an easy problem explains it all, you will get one theory. I you base your theory on the existence of hard problems it will be very different.

> I argue that reductive explanations of consciousness impossible and I even argue for a form of dualism. But this is just a part of the scientific process. Certain sorts of explanation turn out to not work, so we need to embrace other sorts of explanation instead. Everything I say here is compatible with the results of contemporary science; our picture of the natural world is broadened, not overturned. p. xiv

1.2. Foundations

1.2.1. Two Concepts of Mind

What is consciousness?

Chalmers don't use any definition of his own. His definition is formulated through Nagel (1974) p. 4

> We can say that a being is is conscious if there is *something it is like* to be that being.

1.2.2. Phenomenal and Psychological

> On the phenomenal concept, mind is characterised by the way it feels; on the psychological by what it does. p. 11

Functionalism include groups of positions sharing the idea that there exist mental states that cause behaviours. p. 14–15

> At a first approximation, phenomenal concepts deal with the first-person aspects of mind, and psychological concepts deal with the third person aspects. p. 16

1.2.3. The double life of mental terms

> A good test for whether a mental notion M is primarily psychological is to ask oneself: Could something be an instance of M without any particular associated phenomenal quality? p. 18

1.2.4. The two mind-body problems

The fact that we have have two kinds of mental properties has consequences. p. 24

> [...] effect of dividing the mind-body problem into two: an easy part and a hard part. The psychological aspects of mind pose many problems for cognitive science [...] but they pose no deep metaphysical enigmas.

Learning and memory are functions that belong to the easy ones. They might be connected with enormous technical problems, but hardly any metaphysical ones. They are 'puzzles' not 'mysteries'.

> The phenomenal aspects of mind are a different matter. Here, the mind-body problem is as baffling as it ever was. The impressive progress of the physical and cognitive sciences has not shed significant light on the question of how and why cognitive functioning is accompanied by conscious experience. The progress in the understanding of the mind has almostentirely centered on the explanation of behaviour. This progress leaves the question of consious experience untouched. p. 25

Chalmers refers to this problem as the mind-mind problem.

1.2.5. Explaining consciousness versus explaining awareness

Finally Chalmers simplifies his vocabulary p. 31

> In what follows, I revert to using 'consciusness' to refer to phenomenal conciousness alone. When I wish to use the psychological notions, I will speak of 'psychological consciousness' or 'awareness.' It is phenomenal consciusness with which I will mostly be concerned.

1.3. Supervenience and Explanation

1.3.1. Supervenience

> The *A-facts* and *B-facts* about the world are the facts concerning the instantiation and distribution of A-properties and B-properties. [...] The template for the definition of supervenience is the following: B-properties *supervene* on A-properties if no two possible with respect to their A-properties while differing in their B-properties. p. 33

Local and global supervenience — p. 33–34

> B-properties supervene *locally* on A-properties if the A-properties of an *individual* determine the B-properties of that individual.

Chalmers understands 'global' as 'an entire universe' p. 34

> B-properties supervenes globally on A-properties, by contrast, if the A-facts of the entire *world* determines the the B-facts: if there are no two possible worlds identical with respect to A-properties, but differing with respect to their B-properties.

Logical and natural supervenience p. 34–35

> B-properties supervene *logically* on A-properties if no two logically *possible situations* are identical with respect to their A-properties but distinct with respect to their B-properties.

Hence, logical supervenience is not defined in terms of deducabilityh in any system of formal logic, what matters is logically possible worlds (or situations).

Then we have natural supervenience, which poses much more stringent conditions. p. 36

> In general, B-properties supervene naturally on A-properties if any two naturally possible situations with the same A-properties have the same B-properties.

A posteriori necessity p. 56

> On the traditional view of refernce derived from Frege although cloaked here in modern terminology, a concept determines a function $f: W \rightarrow R$ from possible worlds to referents. Such a function is ofthen called an *intension*; together with a specification of a world w, it determines am extension $f(w)$.

Excercise to self: How does this relate to the canonical example with the planet Venus and the two celestial bodies Morning start and Evening star (Phosphorus and Hesperus, respectively)?

Claude explains:

> Start with Frege's original problem. 'Hesperus is Phosphorus' and 'Hesperus is Hesperus' both have the same referent on each side, yet the first was an astronomical discovery and the second is trivial. Frege's answer was that the two names have the same Bedeutung (Venus) but different Sinn — different modes of presentation, roughly 'the body visible in the evening sky' and 'the body visible in the morning sky.' The modernised version in your quote replaces the sense with a function $f: W \to R$. The two names get different intensions: in a world where the evening body and the morning body are two different planets, the functions deliver different objects. They coincide at the actual world, $f(a)$ = Venus for both, which is why the identity is true, but they differ elsewhere, which is why it is informative. The extension is just what you get by feeding in a particular world.
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> That is tidy, and then Kripke ruins it. Names are rigid designators: 'Hesperus' picks out Venus in every world where Venus exists, whatever is hanging in that world's evening sky. So 'Hesperus is Phosphorus,' if true, is necessarily true — a posteriori, but necessary. On the rigid reading, both names determine the same function, the constant function to Venus. And now the single f can no longer do Frege's job at all: two expressions with identical intensions ought to be trivially intersubstitutable and their identity knowable a priori, which it plainly isn't.

Chalmers explains this p. 57

> Kripke's insight can be expressed by saying that there are in fact *two* intensions associated with a given concept. That is, there are two quite distinct patterns of dependence of the referent of a concept on the state of the world. First, there is the dependence by which reference is fixed in the *actual* world, depending on how the world turns out: if it turns out one way, a concept will pick out one thing, but if it turns out another way, the concept with pick out something else. Second, there is the dependence by which reference in *counterfactual* worlds is determined, given that reference in the actual world is already fixed. Corresponding to each of these dependencies is an intension, which I will call *primary* and *secondary* intensions respectively.

References

Chalmers, David J., *The Conscious Mind: In Search of a Fundamental Theory,* Oxford University Press, New York (1996).

Nagel, Thomas, "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" *The Philosophical Review* **83**, pp. 435-450 (1974). https://doi.org/10.2307/2183914.